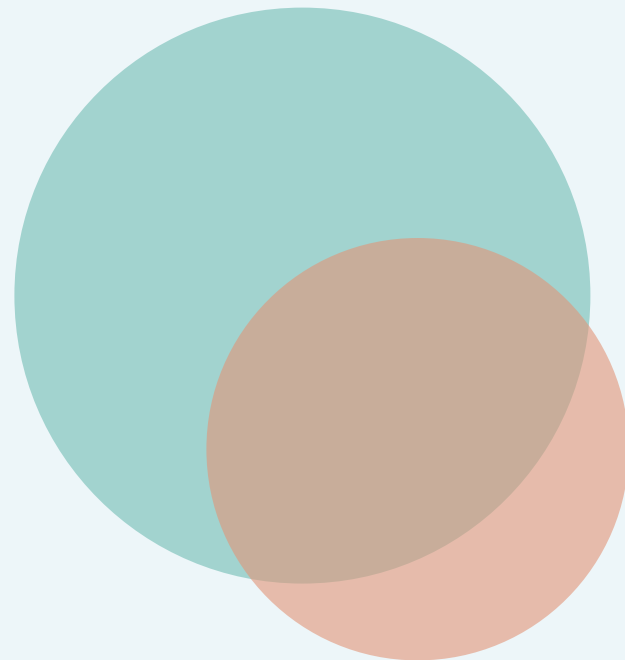


The Global Burden of Mental Illness

Prevalence, Impact, and
the Treatment Gap

2023 Data



Data: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) | Our World in Data

Hundreds of Millions Affected

Lifetime prevalence of major depression

1 in 3

Women

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

1 in 5

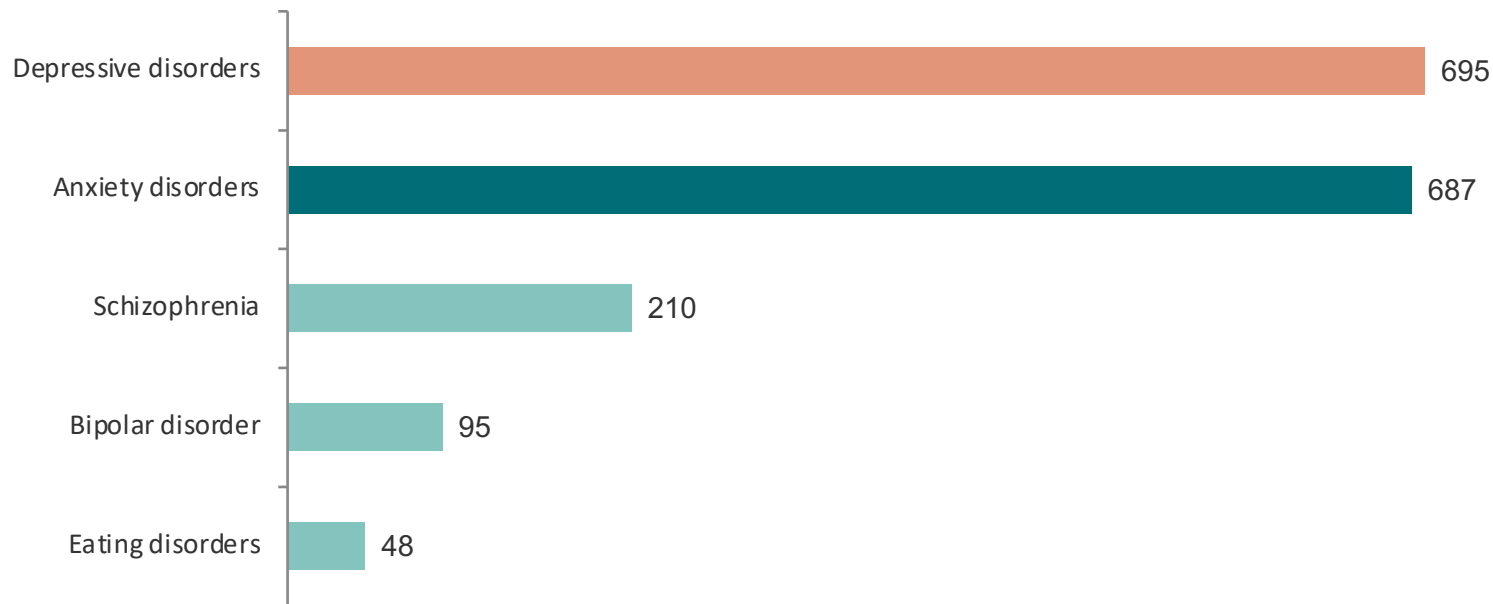
Men

will experience major depression
in their lifetime

Other conditions such as schizophrenia and bipolar disorder are less common but have a large impact on individuals' lives.

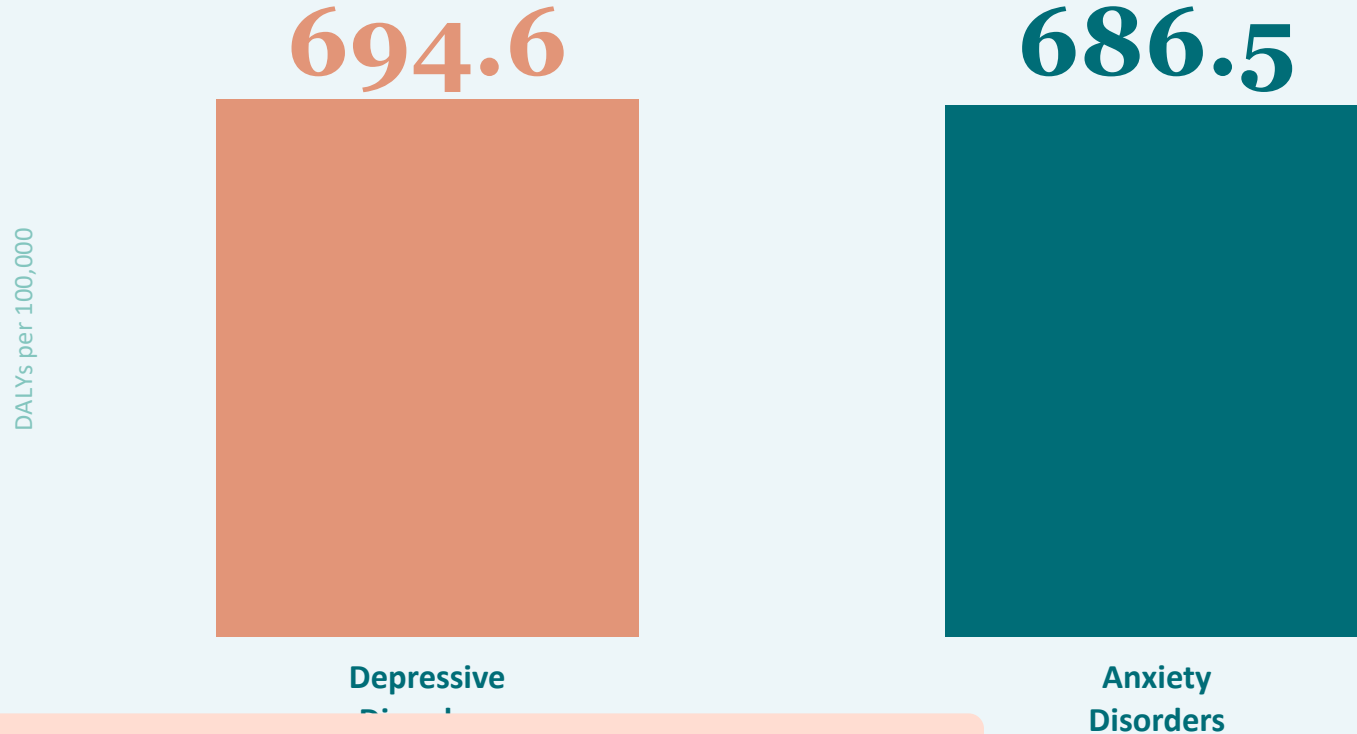
Depression and Anxiety Dominate the Disease Burden

DALYs per 100,000 people, World, 2023



Source: IHME, Global Burden of Disease (2025) | Our World in Data

Depression and Anxiety Carry Nearly Equal Disease Burden



Together they account for ~80% of total mental health DALYs

Lower Prevalence but Severe Individual Impact

Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder affect fewer people, but carry disproportionately high individual burden

210.2

DALYs per 100,000

Schizophrenia

Reflects severe disability associated with the condition despite lower population prevalence

94.6

DALYs per 100,000

Bipolar Disorder

A smaller but meaningful share of the total burden, with significant impact on quality of life

For comparison: depressive disorders = 694.6 | anxiety disorders = 686.5 DALYs per 100,000

Treatment Is Available but Often Lacking or Poor Quality

Mental illnesses are treatable and their impact can be reduced. Yet significant barriers persist:

S

Stigma

Many people are uncomfortable disclosing symptoms to healthcare professionals or even to people they know

A

Access

Treatment is often lacking, especially in low- and middle-income countries

Q

Quality

Even where treatment exists, it may be of poor quality

U

Underreporting

Discomfort with disclosure makes it difficult to estimate the true prevalence of mental illnesses

The true burden of mental illness is likely higher than reported figures suggest.

How People Cope: From Medication to Faith to Family

Global survey data reveals wide variation in how people deal with anxiety or depression



Prescribed Medication

Common in higher-income settings where healthcare systems provide pharmaceutical access



Religious or Spiritual Activities

Prevalent in many regions worldwide as a primary coping mechanism



Talking to Friends or Family

A widely reported coping mechanism across diverse cultural contexts

Responses vary widely across countries, shaped by cultural, economic, and healthcare system factors. Policy interventions must account for these differences.

Key Takeaways

- 1 Depression and anxiety together represent the overwhelming majority of mental health DALYs (~80% of the five major categories)
- 2 Schizophrenia and bipolar disorder carry disproportionate individual burden relative to their prevalence
- 3 Treatment exists but access and quality remain inadequate, especially in low- and middle-income countries
- 4 Stigma suppresses both help-seeking and accurate data, meaning the true burden is likely underestimated
- 5 Policy should prioritize scaling evidence-based interventions for common disorders while maintaining specialized care for severe conditions